A WAR TO END THE CENTURY

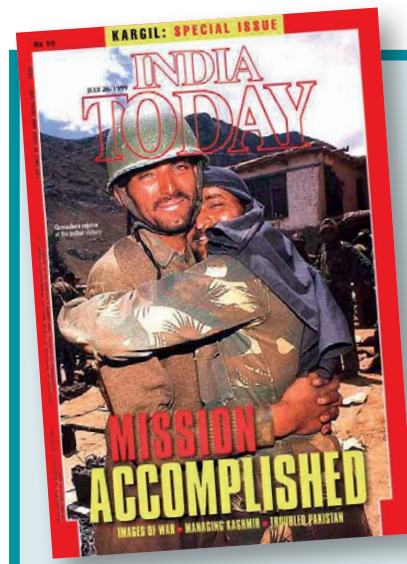
As the leaders sued for peace in Lahore, the Pak army was playing saboteur. The battle to reclaim the high ground on the Kargil road needed howitzers, tactical chutzpah and plenty of fallen heroes

IN

May 1999, just months after the Lahore Declaration high and talk of dialogue and de-escalation, India and Pakistan were again rattling sabres as it came to light that a great deception had happened—enemy soldiers and militants had crossed the Line of Control (LoC) and occupied positions on the icy Kargil heights that Indian forces had vacated during the previous winter.

'Operation Badr', attributed to sections in the Pakistan army leadership, had three objectives—severing key supply routes to Leh and Siachen, internationalising the Kashmir dispute and creating a crisis under the 'nuclear overhang' (the two countries had recently conducted N-tests and were officially in possession of nuclear bombs).

The intrusions were discovered in May 1999 after local shepherds alerted the Indian forces. Soon enough, the army had amassed some 30,000 troops and artillery down below. Initially, there were reverses, as the terrain favoured the intruders—battles were being fought at heights of up to 18,000 feet (5,490 metres) under freezing conditions and against an entrenched enemy perched above. Infantry assaults supported by artillery barrages and air power finally turned the tide. By July 1999, the forces had overrun most of the occupied posts.



Mission Accomplished
Jul. 26, 1999

"So it's all over, done with, finished. All those gunshot wounds and amputated limbs, those telegrams that say your boy has gone, those weeping widows and wounded mothers, all that's ended. No it cannot. For in the darkness of fear from which men never flinched, in the heroic tales of men walking with four bullets sucked into their flesh, in the despairing stories of a captain married one day and dead 10 days later, the war continues. Victory is fine, but as much was won, as much was lost."

WITH NO RECOURSE LEFT, NAWAZ SHARIF ANNOUNCED A WITHDRAWAL ON JULY 4. IT WOULD TAKE INDIAN TROOPS 20 MORE DAYS TO CLEAR OUT THOSE PAKISTANI POSITIONS THAT REFUSED TO STAND DOWN

Meanwhile, New Delhi did well not to widen the scope of the conflict—the military response was confined to our side of the LoC—which earned it major points with the international community. Pakistan, on the other hand, was by now a pariah. Remonstrations to all-weather friend China and to the US brought little sympathy, and finally the diplomatic isolation and economic woes forced then Pakistan prime minister Nawaz Sharif to announce, on July 4, that